

IPKF soldiers of 11 GORKHA RIFLES, the only Gorkha regiment of the Indian Army to be raised after independence, pictured at Trincomalee, 24 March 1990. Initially raised in 1948, the regiment has the proud privilege of having taken part in all major operations undertaken by the Indian Army since independence. Its 1st and 3rd battalions took part in Operation *Pawan*. (Robert Nickelsberg/Getty Images)

During the ensuing assault on Jaffna, the hastily inducted Indian Army infantry battalions found their advance fiercely contested, with the roads strewn with mines and improvised explosive devices. The IPKF took heavy losses, and a massive airlift was undertaken to induct three additional brigades of 36 Infantry Division and heavy equipment including T-72 tanks and BMP-1 IFVs. The fiercest battles between the Indian Army and the 'Tigers' were fought at Kopai North, Kokuvil and Kurruparai, where the LTTE halted the IPKF advance in its tracks. The reinforced IPKF took 16 days to capture Jaffna after losing 214 dead, 700 wounded and 36 missing. The IPKF finally had to deploy Mil Mi-24 helicopter gunships and the LTTE stronghold of Chavakacheri was taken with only a handful of casualties.